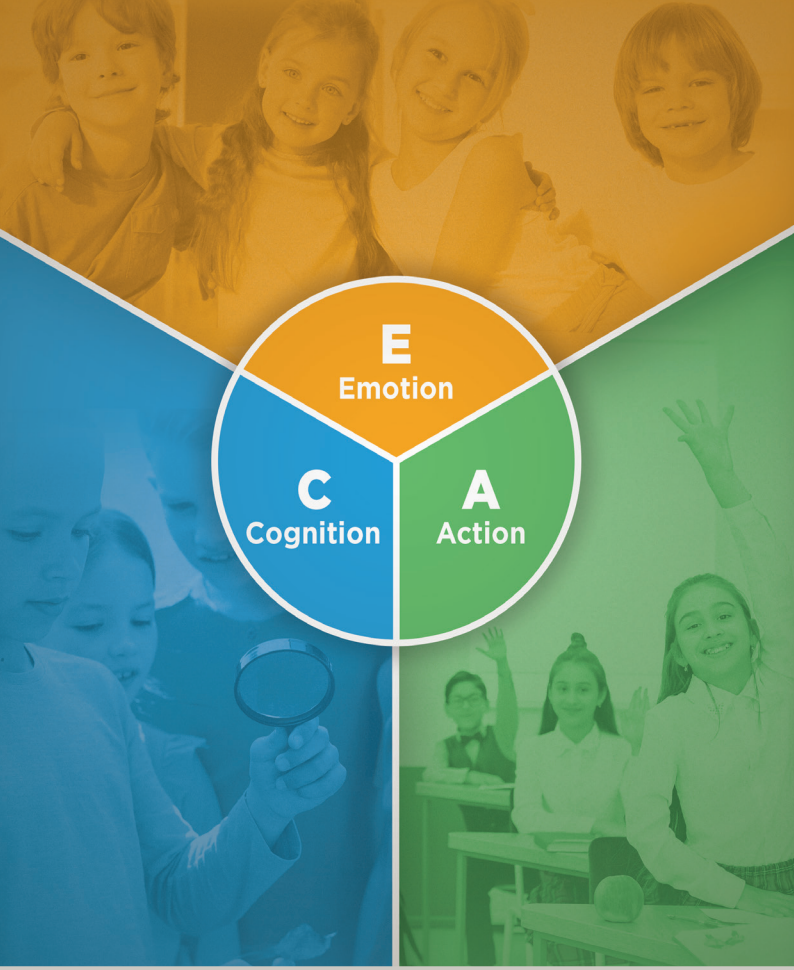


ECA Cards – User Guide

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What are the ECA Cards for?

The ECA Cards support person-centred pedagogical thinking and practice. They are not knowledge cards or worksheets to be completed in a prescribed order. Rather, they invite reflection, self-reflection, dialogue and action.

The cards are built around the three dimensions of **Emotion – Cognition – Action.** In the ECA approach, learning is not simply about understanding information. It also matters how we connect with what we are working on, what emotions and personal experiences we bring into the process, what we understand from it, and ultimately what we do with it in practice.

The three elements of ECA

E – Emotion: What do I feel? What touches me? What can I connect with? What causes resistance or uncertainty in me?

C – Cognition: What do I think about this? What do I understand from it? What connections do I discover? How does all this relate to my own teaching practice?

A – Action: What will I do with it? What will I try out? What will I change? What will my next concrete step be?

The three elements appear in different proportions on the individual cards. Some start more strongly from emotions or personal experience; others primarily encourage thinking and analysis; and still others lead more directly to action. There is therefore no need to classify the cards into E, C and A categories. The point is precisely that emotional connection should lead to thinking and, whenever possible, thinking should lead to action. This transition is also reflected in the cards: the ECA process moves from connection and awareness of emotional states through exploration to creation, practice and reflection.

Further resources

A more detailed presentation of the ECA approach, further methodological background materials, lesson plans and practical resources are available on the project website at ecaproject.eu.

ECA Cards HU 2026. Meseliget Foundation

In what situations can the cards be used?

For individual self-reflection

The cards can also be used individually when a teacher wants to pause for a moment and look at their own practice. A card can help identify emotions, habits, strengths or uncertainties, and then consider their pedagogical significance more consciously. It is important that self-reflection does not stop at recognition: it is worth ending with one small, concrete next step that the teacher can try out in their own practice. This use is particularly well suited to cards dealing with self-assessment and self-reflection.

In pairs and small groups

In pairs or small groups, the cards can primarily support professional dialogue. The same question may evoke different experiences, emotions and interpretations, so the aim is not for participants to arrive at a shared "correct answer". They can listen to one another's perspectives, ask questions, bring examples from their own practice, and then look together for solutions that could be tried out. In this way, working with the cards itself provides practice

in the acceptance, empathy and perspective-taking that are important in ECA.

In training sessions or staff workshops

In a training session, the cards can be used for tuning in, introducing a topic, group processing or closing a session. They make it easier to connect theoretical questions with participants' own teaching experiences. In a staff workshop, they can also help make shared strengths, different viewpoints and areas in which the community would like to change more visible. At the end of the discussion, it is worth choosing a shared action as well: something participants will try out over the following period and later evaluate together.

When working with real teaching situations and lesson planning

The cards can be used not only for reflection but also to shape teaching practice directly. A card chosen for an upcoming lesson, a difficult learning situation, a conflict or a question concerning a particular child can offer a new perspective. It can help us consider what the people involved are experiencing (E), what needs

to be better understood or interpreted differently (C), and what concrete change could be tried out (A). The card on preparing an ECA lesson itself encourages us, alongside our usual planning, to think more consciously about emotional connection, optional activities and different learning resources.

The cards can also be used in mentoring

The cards are particularly useful in mentor–mentee or coach–teacher situations. In such cases, the mentor does not necessarily choose the topic. The teacher can select the card that best connects with their current question.

The mentor's role is primarily to ask questions, listen and reflect back. They do not need to provide a ready-made solution. The aim is for the teacher to recognise for themselves what is happening within them and in the teaching situation, and then choose their own next step.

This use is especially close to the person-centred foundations of the cards. The card on the mentoring role also emphasises listening, recognising individual strengths, jointly developed goals, empathy and a non-judgemental attitude.

Some ideas for using the cards

1. My card for today – individual self-reflection

Choose or draw a card. Do not start answering the questions immediately. First notice your own reaction.

E: What does the card evoke in you? Does it feel familiar, interesting, uncomfortable, inspiring or perhaps irritating?

C: Read it again. Where do you encounter this topic? What are you already doing? What do you see differently?

A: Choose one small thing to try out over the next few days.

You can put the card aside and return to it a few days later: has anything happened since then?

2. Choose by feeling! – a training opener

Lay out several cards so that everyone can see them. Ask participants to choose one that speaks to them for some reason. They do not need to be able to explain why they chose that particular card.

E: What drew you to this card? What was your first reaction?

C: In pairs or small groups, discuss what pedagogical question it raises for you.

A: Everyone completes this sentence: "During today's session, I would like to understand / try out…"

This activity supports both personal arrival and the development of a shared focus for the work.

3. One card – two perspectives

Two participants work with the same card. First, they read it separately and do not discuss it for a few minutes.

E: What touched you? Which part did you react to most strongly?

C: Compare your thoughts. Did you notice the same things? What did you interpret differently?

A: Find a concrete teaching situation in which the idea on the card could be applied.

An important insight from this activity may be that the same pedagogical idea can mean different things to different people – and neither interpretation necessarily has to be "more correct" than the other.

4. Working through a real case

Someone in the group briefly presents a real teaching situation in which they feel uncertain or which causes them difficulty. Group members choose cards that connect with the situation in some way.

E: What happens within us as we listen to the story?

C: Let us look at the situation through the lens of the cards. What do we notice now that we did not see at first?

A: The group formulates several possible next steps. The person who brought the case responds to the suggestions.

Cards dealing with emotional intelligence or mediation are particularly suitable for this. The mediation card itself moves from recognising emotions and expressing needs towards a shared solution and a next step.

5. ECA glasses – lesson planning with a card

Choose a lesson that you will teach in the next few days. Draw a card and use it like a new pair of glasses: what do you see differently in the planned lesson through this lens?

E: How does this aspect affect the children's sense of safety, motivation or emotional engagement?

C: Does it change the questions they are asked or the choices available to them?

A: Change one concrete element of your lesson plan as a result of the card, and try it out.

You do not need to design a completely new lesson every time. One small change is enough.

6. Through the child's eyes – changing perspective

Choose a card and a particular child you teach. This time, do not answer the card's questions as a teacher; try to put yourself in the child's place.

E: How might this child feel in the situation?

C: What might they see differently from you? What might they understand from the situation? What might they need in order to connect?

A: What is one small thing you could change to make the situation better for them?

Cards about differences, autonomy, routines or needs can be particularly useful for this.

7. Three cards – E, C, A

Work in groups of 3–5. Choose three cards: one that, for you at this moment, primarily represents **Emotion,** one **Cognition,** and one **Action.** There is no correct solution. What matters is your reasoning. Discuss why each card was placed where it was. Where can you find the other two ECA elements in it? Then use the three cards to design a short learning situation:

- **E:** How do the children become emotionally engaged?
- **C:** What do they discover, understand or think through?
- **A:** What do they do, create, try out or change?

At the end, the groups present their mini ECA situations to one another.

8. My comfort zone

Look through the cards and choose two. The first should be one that makes you feel: **"I am already comfortable with this."** The second: **"This is difficult for me / I tend to avoid this."**

E: How did it feel to choose the second card? What causes the uncertainty or resistance?

C: What might be the reason? Lack of knowledge? Experience? Lack of time? Fear of losing control? Something else?

A: Do not try to solve the whole problem at once. Find one situation in which you would try something different.

The aim is not to look for shortcomings, but to identify your own next step in development.

9. Staff ECA map

Lay out the cards at a staff or professional workshop. First, everyone chooses one card in response to the question: **“What are we already strong at?”** Then choose another: **“What would it be good for us to develop together?”**

E: What experiences, successes or difficulties are connected with the chosen cards?

C: What pattern emerges? Do we see the same areas as strengths or as areas where something is missing?

A: Together, choose one shared, realistically achievable change to try out.

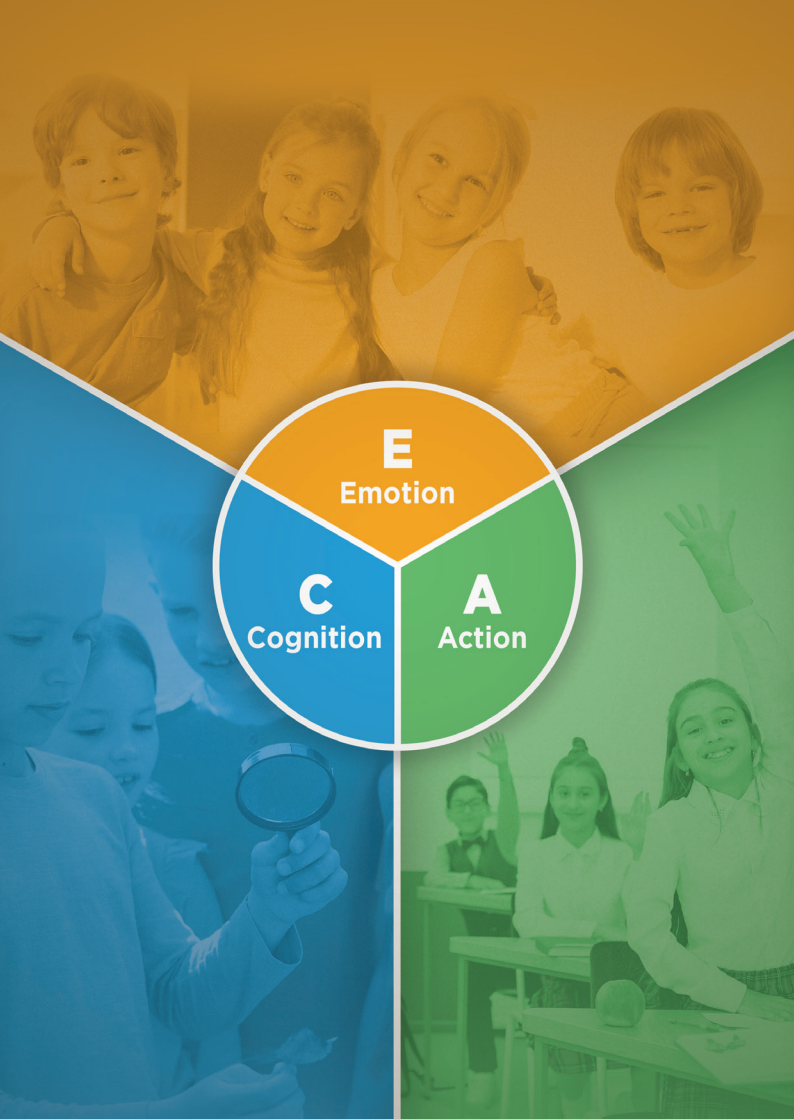
In this way, the cards can support not only individual self-reflection but also the development of a shared pedagogical culture.

10. Draw it again – from reflection to further action

Choose or draw a card and work with it in the usual way.

E: How does this affect you now?
C: What have you recognised or understood?
A: Choose one concrete thing to try out in practice. Then put the card aside. Take it out again a week later – now with the experience you have gained since then. What happened? What worked? What did not? How did you feel? What do you see differently now? What should your next step be? If you wish, you can take the same card with you into the following week.

In this way, ECA becomes not a straight line but a process: **connection → thinking → action → experience → reflection → further action.**


E
Emotion
C
Cognition
A
Action